

Confidential Editor Report (Second Round)

Journal: Journal of Environmental Economics and Management

Paper Title: Environmental Governance and Bureaucratic Incentives in
China's Clean-Air Campaign

Manuscript ID: JEEM-D-26-00040R1

1 Recommendation and Message to Editor

Recommendation: Minor Revision

This is a serious and largely successful revision, and I cross-checked the response letter's claims against the revised manuscript; the responses are accurate. The four central issues from the first round are largely resolved. The new event study and the reframing of the contribution as a reduced-form effect of the clean-air governance regime settle the timing and interpretation concern; the rewritten multitask model now maps one-to-one to the empirical specifications (which also resolves Referee 1's model concerns); and the promotion coding, sample restrictions, and IV diagnostics are documented and stress-tested. The one partially outstanding area is validation of the text-based effort measure.

2 Remaining Required and Suggested Concerns

My remaining points are limited. Two could in principle move results rather than wording: the unreported lower-order interaction terms in the information-gains specification (Table 3), on which the paper's remaining mechanism claim rests, and a direct human-audit validation of the AI-based text classifier, which the authors substituted with coarser proxies. The rest are presentational: calibrating the abstract's mechanism claim to the paper's own hedged language, reconciling an OLS–IV sign contrast in the provincial-leader appendix, and documenting an estimator label. The paper is close to being publishable at JEEM, and I expect a quick final round.